

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

ASSASSINATION OF PM GANDHI MODULE-11



STATE OF PUNJAB



1

The state of Punjab borders Pakistan.

2

The state of Punjab was created in 1966 and the Sikh political party, Akali Dal was unable to authoritatively rule the state.

3

It had put forward some demands in October 1973, the Anandpur Sahib Resolution was passed which demanded-

- to hand over Chandigarh to Punjab (it then shared the city with Haryana);
- to also hand over Punjabi-speaking areas then with other states;
- to increase the proportion of Sikhs in the army.

STATE OF PUNJAB



4

Asking for a recasting of the Indian Constitution on 'real federal principles', it said that 'in this new Punjab and in other States the Centre's interference would be restricted to defence, foreign relations, currency, and general administration; all other departments would be in the jurisdiction of Punjab.'

5

The Akali Dal stressed upon the importance of Sikh brotherhood and for the creation of a 'Sikh Nation' and fulfilling the political goal of the community.

STRONGHOLD OF AKALIS IN PUNJAB



1 These demands were revived after the end of Emergency in 1977.

2 The Akalis claimed a greater share of these waters; to this economic demand was coupled a cultural one, the designation of Amritsar, home to the holiest Sikh shrine, the Golden Temple, as a 'Holy City'.

3 There was also the revival of the Khalistan movement. Even though the Khalistan movement started in the early 1940s and 1950s, it gained popularity between 1970s and 1980s.

4 The Khalistan movement was a political Sikh nationalist movement which aimed at creating an independent state for Sikhs inside the current North-Western Republic of India.

STRONGHOLD OF AKALIS IN PUNJAB



BHINDRANWALE

5 In April 1978 there was a mass convention at Amritsar of a religious sect, the Nirankari, who thought themselves to be Sikhs.

- 6**
- Their leader Bhindranwale was an inspiring preacher with a deep knowledge of Sikh scriptures.
 - He claimed that Sikhs 'were slaves in independent India', discriminated against by the Hindus.
 - Bhindranwale wanted the Sikhs to purify themselves and return to the fundamentals of their faith. (Some accounts claim that Bhindranwale was encouraged by Sanjay Gandhi and Zail Singh as a counter to Akalis.)

ROLE OF BHINDRANWALE



1 Bhindranwale had a strong following. He attracted many Jats of a peasant background who had seen the gains of the Green Revolution being cornered by the large landowners.

2 Other followers came from the lower Sikh castes of artisans and labourers; they saw in the process of purification their own social advancement.

3 Bhindranwale also benefited from the general increase of religiosity which, in the Punjab as in some other places, followed upon rapid and unexpected economic development.

ROLE OF BHINDRANWALE



BHINDRANWALE



BABA HARDEV SINGH
SPIRITUAL GURU OF NIRANKARIS

4 In April 1978 in Amritsar, Bhindranwale preached an angry sermon from the precincts of the Golden Temple. A crowd of Sikhs descended upon the place where the heretics were meeting.

5 The Nirankaris fought back; in the battle that ensued, fifteen people died.

6 Sikh pride took another blow in 1980, when the Akalis were dismissed and the Congress returned to power in Punjab.

ROLE OF BHINDRANWALE



7 Radical separatist Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, who was reportedly backed by Pakistan's ISI, had made his demands clear - he wanted the Indian government to pass a resolution which would allow India to be divided, thereby creating a new country for Sikhs called 'Khalistan'.

8 Bhindranwale had started laying the groundwork for his demand in 1982, and by mid-1983 managed to gain support for his plan to divide India.

9 His operations and plans were reportedly supported by Pakistan's ISI, which helped him in spreading militancy in the state, and also provided him with arms and ammunition.

THE HOLY GOLDEN TEMPLE



1 In June of that year a group of students met at the Golden Temple and proclaimed the formation of an independent Sikh republic. The republic had a name, Khalistan.

2 Primarily it was Sikh emigres who were behind this move; the pronouncement was made simultaneously in the United Kingdom, the United States, Canada and France.

3 Their new leader, Sant Harcharan Singh Longowal, lodged himself in the Golden Temple, from where he would announce street protests on a variety of themes such as the handing over of Chandigarh, or the greater allocation of canal water.

THE HOLY GOLDEN TEMPLE



4

Bhindranwale was operating from another part of the temple. He had acquired a group of devoted gun-toting followers.

5

While the CM of Punjab was pursuing Bhindranwale, he turned himself in. He turned out to be a hero who challenged the Indian government.

6

He decided to transform the face of the Sikhs and described them as a separate 'quam' or community but which was implicitly hinting towards a separate 'nation'.

PRESIDENT'S RULE



Major General **R. S. BRAR**

- 1 On 6 October 1983, President's Rule was imposed in the state. In the last weeks of 1983 Bhindranwale took up residence in the Akal Takht, a building second in importance only to the Golden Temple. Hindu-Sikh conflict was, in the context of Indian history, unprecedented.
- 2 By 1984, Bhindranwale's men had begun fortifying the Golden Temple,
- 3 On 31 May Major General R. S. Brar told he would have to lead the operation to rid the temple of terrorists. The government believed that the situation in the Punjab had passed out of control of the civil administration.

OPERATION BLUESTAR



HARMANDIR SAHIB COMPLEX

1

Operation Blue Star was launched to eliminate Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and other Sikh militants who had taken cover in the Amritsar Harmandir Sahib Complex.

2

- The 1984 Operation Blue Star was the biggest internal security mission ever undertaken by the Indian Army.
- Operation Blue Star was Indira Gandhi's solution to the haywire going law and order situation in Punjab.

OPERATION BLUESTAR



1

The Akali leader Sant Longowal had announced that on 3 June, 1984 he would lead a movement to stop the passage of grain from the state.

2

The prime minister had thus decided, that the militants had to be flushed out.

3

Brar was asked to plan and lead what was being called 'Operation Bluestar', with the mandate that it should be finished in forty-eight hours if possible, with no damage to the Golden Temple itself and with minimum loss of life.

4

On the night of the 2nd June, the prime minister spoke on All-India Radio. She appealed to 'all sections of Punjab' not to shed blood.

5

On the 3rd, Punjab's road, rail and telephone links were cut off, but in Amritsar itself the curfew was lifted to allow pilgrims to mark the anniversary of the martyrdom of Guru Arjun Dev.

OPERATION BLUESTAR

Operation Blue Star was divided into two parts from June 1 to June 10, 1984



1

Operation Metal:

- ✓ It was limited to Golden Temple but it also led to Operation Shop which raided the Punjab countryside, in order to capture any suspects.

2

Operation Woodrose

- ✓ It was launched throughout Punjab. The operation was carried out by Indian Army, using tanks, artillery, helicopters and armoured vehicles.

OPERATION SUNDOWN

- Operation Sundown was the aborted mission which was planned by the RAW agency to abduct Bhindranwale.

MILITANCY IN THE GOLDEN TEMPLE



- 1 Announcements were broadcast over loudspeakers asking pilgrims to leave the temple. The attack itself was launched on the night of the 5th.
- 2 Brar's hope was that the peripheral parts of the temple would be seized by midnight, after which a lodgement would be placed within the Akal Takht, reinforcements sent up and the whole place cleared by the morning of the next day.
- 3 His plan grievously underestimated the number of militants, their firepower, their skill and their resolve.

CONSEQUENCES OF THE OPERATION



4

- Permission from Delhi was requested to use tanks to break the defences.
- Several tanks had broken through the temple's gates and taken up position.
- The government estimated the death toll at 4 officers, 79 soldiers and 492 'terrorists'.

5

- Though the intent of Operation Bluestar and the armed rebels that it was directed against were not similar to the Jallianwala Bagh incident, the consequences were similar.
- It left a collective wound in the psyche of the Sikhs, crystallizing a deep suspicion against the government of India.
- Those Sikhs who had previously opposed Bhindranwale began to see him in a new light.
- The view from outside Punjab was quite different. Many people commended Gandhi for taking firm action against terrorists claimed to be supported by Pakistan.

ASSASSINATION OF INDIRA GANDHI



Beanth Singh and Satwant Singh



- 1 In the aftermath of Operation Bluestar the prime minister had been warned by intelligence agencies of a possible attempt on her life.
- 2 She was advised to change the Sikh members of her personal bodyguard. On the morning of 31 October, while walking from her home to her office next door, she was shot at point-blank range by two of her security guards.
- 3 Sikhs had been provoked by the hurt and anger they witnessed to take revenge for Operation Bluestar.

Shortly afterwards her son Rajiv Gandhi was sworn in as prime minister.

ANTI-SIKH RIOTS



1 The violence that began on the night of 31 October, spread and intensified through the first two days of November. The first serious episodes occurred in south and central Delhi.

2 Sikhs alone were the target. Their homes were burnt, their shops looted, their shrines and holy books violated and desecrated.

ANTI-SIKH RIOTS



- 1 The worst affected areas were Sultanpuri, Mangolpuri, Trilokpuri, and other Trans-Yamuna areas of Delhi.
- 2 Mobs made use of iron rods, knives, and combustible material such as kerosene and petrol.
- 3 The mob attacked Sikh neighbourhoods, brutally killing any Sikh men or women they could find. Their shops and houses were destroyed and burned.
- 4 In other incidents, armed mobs also stopped buses and trains, in and around Delhi. They pulled out Sikh passengers, who were doused with kerosene and burnt alive.
- 5 Others were dragged out from their homes and attacked with bladed weapons.

BOMBING OF AIR INDIA FLIGHT 182



1

On June 23, 1985, Air India Flight 182 which was operating on the Montreal-London-Delhi route was blown up by a bomb at an altitude of 31,000 feet (9,400 m).

2

The plane crashed into the Atlantic Ocean. A total of 329 people were killed, in which 268 were Canadians, 27 British citizens and 24 Indians.

3

The majority of the victims who died were Indo-Canadians. The incident was the largest mass murder in Canadian history. The attack was considered to be a retaliation against India for the Operation Blue Star. Inderjit Singh Reyat, a Canadian national, was the only person legally convicted of involvement in the bombing.

OPERATION BLACK THUNDER



1

- India saw a repeat of Operation Blue Star a few years later.
- Operation Black Thunder was the name given to two operations that took place in India in the late 1980s, to flush out remaining Sikh activists from the Golden Temple.

2

- Operation Black Thunder was the second phase of Operation Blue Star.
- The first phase was carried out on April 30, 1986, while the second Operation Black Thunder began on May 9, 1988.

OPERATION BLACK THUNDER



3 It was carried out by Black Cat commandos of National Security Guards (NSG) to remove Sikh militants from the Golden Temple.

4 Little damage was inflicted on the Golden Temple, compared to Operation Blue Star.

5 It is known for the free access given to the media, unlike during Operation Blue Star.

Operation Black Thunder was far more successful, compared to Operation Blue Star.

NANAVATI COMMISSION



Justice G.T.Nanavati

1 The commission was headed by Justice G.T.Nanavati, a retired Judge of the Supreme Court, appointed by the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government in May 2000, to investigate the "killing of innocent sikhs" during the 1984 Anti-Sikh riots.

2 The commission was mandated to submit its report within six months, but it took five years. The report in two volumes was completed in February 2005.

NANAVATI COMMISSION



The objectives of the Commission were:

- a) to inquire into the causes and course of the events leading to violence and riots against members of the Sikh community
- b) whether there were any lapses or dereliction of duty in this regard on the part of any of the responsible authorities /individuals;
- c) to recommend measures which may be adopted to meet the ends of the justice;

FINDINGS OF NANAVATI COMMISSION

- 1 The commission reported accusations and evidence against senior members of the then ruling Congress Party including Jagdish Tytler, later a Cabinet Minister, MP Sajjan Kumar and late minister H.K.L.Bhagat.
- 2 They were accused of instigating mobs to avenge the assassination of Indira Gandhi by killing Sikhs in their constituencies.
- 3 The report also held the then Lt. Governor PG Gava for failure in his duty and late orders for controlling of the riots.
- 4 The Commission also held the then Delhi police commissioner S.C. Tandon directly responsible for the riots.
- 5 The report led to the resignation of Jagdish Tytler from the Union Cabinet.
- 6 A few days after the report the Indian Prime Minister Dr Manmohan Singh also apologised to the Sikh community for Operation Blue Star and riots that followed

FINDINGS OF NANAVATI COMMISSION



- The Khalistan movement, they believed, was aimed at tearing the country into pieces, and the fact that it was two Sikhs who had killed the prime minister seemed to confirm these fears.
- The long-term result of the operation left the "ISI-backed" Khalistan movement defeated.
- It also left India united, and Punjab free of militancy, and ensured that the Golden Temple is free of violence, guns and ammunition.

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